

**Medford Public Schools
Medford School Committee
Committee of the Whole
Vocational Education
January 14, 2013
7:00 p.m.
Superintendent's Conference Room
Medford High School**

The meeting was called to order by Vice Chairperson John Falco at 7:05 p.m. The following members were present: Ann Marie Cugno, Erin DiBenedetto, John Falco, George Scarpelli, Robert E. Skerry Jr., and Paulette Van der Kloot. Also present: Superintendent Roy E. Belson, Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson, Director of Administration and Finance Ann Giombetti, Vocational Director William C. Mahoney, Interim Assistant Director Jill Sawyer, Headmaster John Perella, Vocational Alumnus Steven Honeycutt, and Medford Transcript Reporter Nicholas Iovino.

All rose to salute the Flag.

Mr. Falco stated that the purpose of the meeting was to review the programs and services of the Medford Vocational Technical High School. He then called upon Superintendent Belson for an overview.

The Superintendent explained that this topic would require multiple meetings including a visit to a regional vocational school (Shawsheen). The first step would be to become familiar with the current program at the Medford Vocational. Later on the School Committee could consider the various options for the future. He also explained the current Minuteman situation and how the cost of outside tuitions was a significant drain on the vocational and system budgets. The Superintendent met earlier in the day with DESE officials and was assured that the department was taking steps to reduce the burden of outside tuitions and transportation on independent vocational schools like Medford. He referenced (see attached) three pieces of legislation that had been filed by Medford through Representative Donato. The DESE Task Force on Non-Resident Vocational Issues which was originally scheduled to meet on December 17, 2012 will now meet on January 30, 2013.

Director Mahoney discussed the current program. There are 212 students in 11 programs at the vocational. These programs include auto collision repair, auto technology, carpentry, construction technology, cosmetology, culinary arts, early childhood, electrical, graphic communications, health assisting and HVAC. Mr. Mahoney discussed his budget (see attached) calling it insufficient to support the program. He has had to rely on resources from outside advisory members and alumni to do what needs to be done. He spoke of the inability to provide textbooks and to repair important shop equipment.

“The alumni group was never set up to buy basic items that should be covered by taxpayer dollars.”

Voke graduate Steven Honeycutt commented that the Medford Vocational School always had a great reputation and that it was jeopardized by low investment in basic educational materials and supplies.

Superintendent Belson acknowledged that budget dollars were low but countered that there were some substantial investments in the voke in recent years. He also cited the increasing drain of Minuteman on the budget.

Ms. DiBenedetto stressed the need to upgrade equipment. Also that parents want a program that allows vocational training and honors/AP courses at the same time. Mr. Mahoney commented that the Voke is working to make that easier to happen with the new Headmaster.

Mr. Scarpelli asked what the breakdown of enrollment was by shop. Mr. Mahoney did not have specific figures with him but indicated that the range was from 4-20.

Mr. Falco asked about jobs as a result of vocational education. Mr. Mahoney talked about the Cooperative Program.

Mr. Skerry raised the issue of a plumbing program in Medford. The Superintendent responded that a startup program of that type would cost about \$250,000. Also there would be a recurring annual cost for staff and materials.

Ms. Cugno asked about how we were marketing our programs to middle school students. Mr. Mahoney talked about the three open houses this year. Also Ms. Sawyer talked about her visits to the middle schools to recruit students.

Ms. Van der Kloot stressed the need to get new ideas into the mix by reaching out to alumni and parents.

The Committee also discussed the potential of certain new programs like Environmental Science, Biotechnology, and Robotics that will be possible with the new Science Lab Initiative. Mr. Mahoney warned that these programs would require additional post secondary study. They were not vocational school to work prototypes. Still the Committee felt that these types of programs could attract more students to our vocational program. Also that a hybrid model of our vocational school would be needed going into the future.

Minuteman was going to develop new programs like Theater Arts, Animal Science, and Criminal Justice. It is hard to gauge whether these programs will take off in the near future but they might be attractive to Medford students. Mr. Mahoney stated that the Vocational had not received eight MACS that he thought were a part of the technology bond. The Superintendent will look into that matter.

Headmaster Perella commented that he was prepared to work closely with the Vocational to facilitate interactive programming. He could envision different models emerging over time.

The Committee consensus was that the vocational school needed attention and new models should be considered.

A date for the visit to Shawsheen will be explored.

On the motion of Mr. Scarpelli, seconded by Mr. Skerry the meeting was adjourned at 9:12 p.m.

Respectfully Submitted,

John Falco
Vice Chairperson